

Great Mosque of Djenné

A sacred mud-brick building that towers over an ancient trading city in West Africa



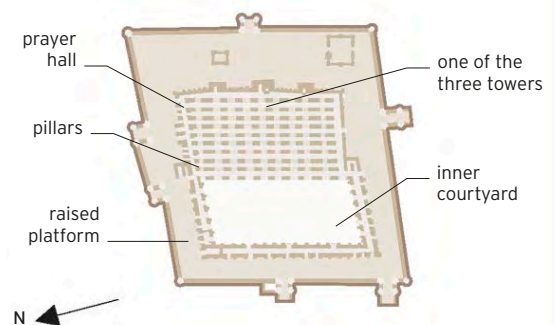
The first mud-brick Great Mosque at the Malian town of Djenné was built around 700 years ago. The current building was constructed in 1906–1907, when Mali was ruled by a French colonial administration. A local master-builder, Ismaila Traoré, was responsible for the work, employing long-established mud-building techniques.

A changing structure

The bricks of the mosque were made by mixing mud and sand with husks and straw, then drying them in sunshine. The flat earthen roof is supported by pillars rising from the sand floor. The walls are protected against the elements by a layer of plaster, composed of river silt mixed with other materials that may include dry rice husks and cow manure. The plaster has to be reapplied almost every year, an activity that has become a ceremony in which the whole community joins. The constant repairs to the structure mean that the detail of its appearance is ever changing.

THE PARTS OF THE MOSQUE

The mosque is a striking example of Sudano-Sahelian architecture. Built on a raised platform to protect against floods, it consists of a walled courtyard and a large prayer hall. Inside the prayer hall, 90 pillars in 10 rows support the mud-and-palm roof. Three large towers protrude from the front of the building.



◁ MUD FACADE

The high mud walls and towers of the Great Mosque are patterned with protruding bundles of palm wood. An ostrich egg is placed at the apex of each tower to symbolize fertility.

▷ IMPRESSIVE SCALE

An aerial view shows the great extent of the mosque. With a prayer hall 165 ft (50 m) long and towers around 52 ft (16 m) high, the mosque is the world's largest mud-built structure.

